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Aspirational place-making and digital practices of refugees in the Netherlands

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ABSTRACT

While much has been written about the experience of human displacement and the trauma of exile, our understanding of how refugees (re)build a sense of place is underemphasised. The literature on refugee integration has mainly focused on the outcomes of integration policies as well as on the perspectives of host societies regarding what is expected of refugees in the integration process. In this article, we propose the notion of *aspirational place-making* to analyze the agency of refugees in negotiations of possible futures and aspirational places in the face of structural challenges of integration within the host community. We argue that refugees turn to digital practices to conceive aspirational places and create their own pathways to belong. The outcomes presented in this study derived from in-depth case study examinations of refugees' lived experiences and aspirations in the Netherlands. In this study, *aspirational place-making* is outlined into three themed categories of digital practices among refugees: (1) digital learning, (2) digital social participation, and (3) digital social support. The empirical findings provide a new understanding of the different strategies refugees employ to construct plans for their lives that can potentially enable them to fulfil aspirations in the host country.

KEYWORDS

Aspirations; place-making; digital practices; refugee integration; agency

Introduction

Jamila was only 18 years-old when she decided to leave Eritrea. Little did she know, it would take her 7 years to finally make it out of the country. In the course of that time, Jamila was forced into military service after spending two years in jail for attempting to leave the country illegally. Jamila, like many other Eritreans, was seeking to escape from the 'open prison' that her country had become, and in which she lived practically alone (her siblings and family had already left Eritrea), for more than a decade. Even though she had set The Netherlands as her final destination, Jamila settled in different

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countries, including Sudan, Uganda, and Ethiopia before reuniting with her older brother in Europe; and despite the many difficulties of her journey, she did not deviate from her goal: a place that would allow her to feel in control of her future, her time, and her dreams. But how do these aspirations play out once a newcomer like Jamila arrives in a host country to settle?

In this article we introduce the notion of *aspirational place-making* as a lens to investigate how refugees in the Netherlands like Jamila, negotiate potential futures and aspirational places while contending structural opportunities and challenges related to the integration framework imposed on them by the host country. In doing so, we analyze the role of different everyday digital practices adopted by the participants to contest, shape, or adapt to the host society's approach to integration. In order to capture the complex dynamics underpinning integration processes (Borselli and van Meijl 2021; Easton-Calabria and Wood 2021), we aimed to place the refugees' individual experiences as the central point of departure in this study. This approach is particularly relevant considering the assimilation paradigm that prevails in countries like the Netherlands, under which refugees like Jamila are at a continuous disadvantage: regardless of how much they adapt to the values and behaviours of the dominant culture, refugees are hardly seen as more than mere 'supplicants' for citizenship, playing at odds with their agency to follow their individual choices to realise their plans and dreams (Appadurai 2019).

This paper begins by examining the relation between place, belonging, integration, and aspirations with a focus on refugees' agency. Following this section, the paper outlines the various digital practices adopted by refugees to negotiate their position regarding migrant integration policies in the Netherlands, which are subsequently described. The methodological approach and considerations about the research's contextual framework are presented next. In the final part of the paper, three themes are developed using different case studies of the participants in this research, drawing from the in-depth interviews conducted. Finally, the discussion and conclusions section offers further reflections on the application of the *aspirational place-making* concept to the study of digital media use by refugees, with a particular focus on their agency vis-à-vis integration.

Aspirational places in refugee integration

The complexity of issues regarding the process of integration for refugees and their impact on host communities have become central topics of debate across the globe. Yet, while much has been written about the experience of displacement and the trauma of exile, our understanding of refugees' agency to restore a sense of place, their processes of emplacement, place-making and settlement is underemphasised. Research that conceptualises and measures 'integration' among refugees has primarily focused on the outcomes of integration policies as well as on the expectations host societies have for refugees during the integration process (Strang and Ager 2010). Within the literature, critics of integration argue that the applications of the concept tend to reflect binary constructions of the individual refugee vs. receiving country, where refugees are required to acquire certain skills and conform to a set of values and behaviours to adapt to the new place (Etzet 2022). Such approaches undermine how refugees' participation in and identification with their receiving society shape integration, which risks reinforcing conceptions of refugees as powerless victims who lack agency for rebuilding

a new life elsewhere (Brun 2001, 18). In this regard, migration scholars highlight that the development of conceptual frameworks that can more meaningfully engage with the ability of migrants to exert agency within broader constraint and opportunity structures constitutes ‘the central challenge in advancing migration theory’ (De Haas 2021, 9).

Recently, a growing number of studies have recognised the importance of centring refugees’ agency in their analyses to better capture the complex dynamics underpinning integration processes. The work of Easton-Calabria and Wood (2021) advances knowledge of integration by focusing on refugees’ personal experiences of establishing and forming part of refugee-led organisations or initiatives in their new country, highlighting the role refugees play in providing support and fostering adaptation to their host community. In Spencer and Charsley’s (2021) innovative integration model, the agency of refugees is emphasised in their negotiations of integration across a comprehensive set of dimensions and through the analysis of ‘effectors’ shaping the integration process for refugees, such as individual human capital, transnational networks of family and social relations, opportunity structures within host society and policy interventions. In line with a migrant-centered approach to integration, Borselli and van Meijl (2021) examine the specific life trajectories refugees create to pursue their aspirations and how these trajectories can be altered to respond to structural constraints of their new environment. According to the authors, the analysis of individual characteristics and aspirations acknowledges refugees as active participants in the making of their own life projects, instead of simply positioning them in a continuum of assimilation to the host society. Therefore, considering aspirations as a form of agency can reveal much about how refugees take action to realise specific goals and how this shapes their experiences of integration in the new place (Borselli and van Meijl 2021; Van Heelsum 2017).

In this study, a perspective on aspirations is used to highlight individual motivations and desires, as well as particular expectations grounded in social constructions and imaginaries of places (Appadurai 2019; Boccagni 2017). Aspirations can be defined as the ‘personal ability to believe in a given life environment’, based on present life circumstances and the experience and memory of the past (Boccagni 2017). Specifically focusing on aspirational life trajectories of refugees in receiving societies, theories that address the production of place can be helpful to understand the different strategies refugees employ to (re)construct plans for their lives in the host country. Place is not naturally conceived; it is a product of people’s engagement in complex networks of social interactions and mental constructs that occur in a physical space (Fataar and Rinqest 2019). We can therefore think of place as an on-going and constantly negotiated process that emerges from a complex web of social relations and forms of practice shaping everyday life experiences, subjective goals and meaning-making in specific spaces (Massey 2005). Turning an unknown location or city into a livable and familiar place involves establishing multiple connections to the new surroundings as well as (re)creating social practices that allow people to make a place for themselves.

Lefebvre’s (1991) seminal work on the production of space provides theoretical ground for the analysis of refugees’ place-making in this study. The author states that space is produced through dynamic interactions between three different spheres: the *physical*, *social* and *mental*. The first dimension of spatial practice, also referred to as perceived space, is experienced through our senses. This dimension of space considers

physical spaces, such as cities' neighbourhoods and public spaces, and highlights people's perceptions of those spaces in ways that fit their own experience and social reality (Fataar and Rinquest 2019). Second, the social sphere of space, also known as lived space, states that space is 'produced and modified over time and through its use ... invested with symbolism and meaning' (Elden 2004, 190). It is about the way people navigate the space and ascribe meaning to it through its associated images and symbols. The third sphere consists of the mental or imagined space. Here space is characterised by a mental process that derives from people's experiences with the social and physical space (Fataar and Rinquest 2019, 3). This dimension refers to the space of 'inhabitants' and 'users'. It is 'the dominated – and hence passively experienced – space which the imagination seeks to change and appropriate' (Lefebvre 1991, 42).

For this article, we view the mental dimension of space as a crucial aspect of refugees' belonging and identification processes, as well as of their ability to conceive possible life trajectories or 'capacity to aspire' (Appadurai 2019). Belonging, as defined by the idea of 'feeling at home' or 'feeling safe', involves 'an act of self-identification or identification by others, in a stable, contested, or transient way' (Yuval-Davis 2006, 199). According to Yuval-Davis (2006), these identifications form narratives that encompass both belonging to specific collectives and personal attributes, experiences, and aspirations, serving as a prospect for future paths (202). We therefore argue that mental space not only comprises identity narratives about the reality of past and present, but also the envisioning of imagined and future reality as a possibility guiding everyday place-making experiences for refugees. This mental process of place-making is referred to in this study as 'aspirational place-making' and underscores refugees' agency in negotiations of possible futures and aspirational places in the face of structural opportunities and challenges of integration processes within the host community (Spencer and Charsley 2021). When examining the efforts of powerful entities to uphold boundaries, also known as the 'politics of belonging', Yuval-Davis (2006, 205) highlights the ability of social groups to contest and question these boundaries as part of their struggle for belonging. In line with this, we hold that aspirational place-making allows for refugees' adoption of multilayered forms of belonging, which include diverse, heterogeneous socio-spatial practices that can challenge while simultaneously conforming to the host society's integration policy. In the section that follows, it will be argued that refugees have turned to digital practices to conceive these aspirational places and create their own paths to belong.

Digital practices of (aspirational) place-making

There is a growing body of literature that recognises the importance of technologies in shaping aspirational forms of place among refugees. Previous research has demonstrated that refugees creatively engage with smartphones to cultivate a sense of hope and mobility toward the future while living in prolonged conditions of uncertainty. The study by Greene (2020), for instance, showed that refugee women waiting in refugee camps in Greece take photos and record videos of nature environments to orient themselves towards other places where they could potentially belong to 'something material and enduring'. According to Twigt (2018), smartphones serve as crucial orientation devices for Iraqi refugees in Jordan awaiting resettlement and seeking to learn English and

acquire practical skills, while Godin and Ghislain (2025) demonstrate that Congolese refugees create YouTube channels to shape their futures beyond their prolonged displacement in Kenya. These aspirational uses of technology enable them to nurture their dreams and envision new lives elsewhere.

Specifically focusing on refugees' place-making experiences in integration and resettlement contexts, scholars have demonstrated an increased interest in examining the practical applications of digital technologies by refugees to address post-migration challenges and navigate the new realities of life (Alencar 2018). A utilitarian perspective on place-making among refugees has given rise to research focusing on the use of smartphones to establish new connections and create common spaces of cultural belonging in their new country. Nevertheless, this utility-driven perspective has been criticised for promoting a sense of exceptionalism surrounding smartphone adoption by refugees, which in turn reinforces oversimplified and essentialist views of these populations, further perpetuating the 'process of othering' (Awad and Tossell 2021). Refugees do not use smartphones in fundamentally different ways simply because they are refugees; however, the media practices enabled by these devices underscore the unique challenges they face in displacement, such as navigating routes and providing evidence in asylum interviews.

Furthermore, social media platforms allow marginalised migrant groups to express their aspirations of belonging to particular socio-economic, national, cultural and digital communities (Jaramillo-Dent, Alencar, and Asadchy 2022; Witteborn 2019). In Witteborn's (2019) research, it was found that people seeking asylum used digital space to present idealised versions of themselves, allowing them to be seen beyond the labels of 'asylum seekers' or 'refugees' with which they often did not identify. The digital strategies employed by refugees to highlight the nuanced and multilayered nature of their identities contribute to reinserting their agency into discussions about their sense of belonging. This challenges symbolic boundary drawing by powerful actors who seek to impose a singular focus on assimilation within society, as well as a fixed and limited conception of the identities and aspirations of refugee populations. In this regard, Jaramillo-Dent, Alencar, and Asadchy's (2022) study showed that migrants are negotiating the algorithmic affordances of platforms, like TikTok, to create diverse storylines to challenge prevailing narratives of exclusion and discrimination, while also nurturing networks of support among migrants to foster a sense of belonging. However, recent evidence suggests that refugees' place-making through digital storytelling has been increasingly constrained by 'larger symbolic regimes of ordering' (Chouliaraki and Georgiou 2019), which grants visibility to migrant individuality without providing genuine sociopolitical recognition (Witteborn 2021). As an example, the acknowledgement of refugee narratives online is contingent on the representation of their entrepreneurial identity (Georgiou 2019). At the same time, state and non-state actors are shaping refugees' place-making experiences through the adoption of technology in the governance of migration. These entities scrutinise social media activity and utilise digital identifications, registrations, and algorithmic sorting to verify refugees' identities and determine their eligibility for rights, assistance, and services (Humphris, Hudson, and Bazurli 2025; Leurs 2023), a process that, according to Witteborn (2021, 5), has the potential to confine 'place-making to an imagined realm of endless aspiration'.

Asylum and refugee integration in the Netherlands

There are two separate paradigms regarding the reception of refugees in the Netherlands. The first paradigm involves the ‘deterrent approach’ adopted in the Dutch asylum system, which aims to discourage migrants from seeking asylum by limiting access to benefits, employment, and housing (Bakker, Cheung, and Phillimore 2016). Only after asylum is granted that migrants have full right to work and access to health, education, and social benefits in the country. At the same time, the fact that asylum seekers are generally housed in remote camps and asylum centres that are situated far from local communities serves to further entrench marginalisation throughout the asylum process (Huizinga and van Liempt 2024). This arrangement results in significant social isolation and has adverse effects on mental well-being among asylum migrants (Bakker, Cheung, and Phillimore 2016). Moreover, the Dutch authorities have been extracting data from the mobile phones of a selected number of asylum applicants as part of the assessment of their cases. Although this practice in the Netherlands has not received as much criticism as it has in other European countries – partially because it did not pass the Dutch parliament –, it gives rise to serious ethical concerns regarding privacy rights, inadequate informed consent, and a lack of transparency (Ozkul 2023, 53).

The second paradigm pertains to the Dutch government’s assimilation-oriented approach, where the concept of integration is narrowed down to conforming to the norms and practices of the dominant culture (Bakker, Cheung, and Phillimore 2016). In this approach, refugees are required to attend civic integration courses aimed at learning the Dutch language, gaining knowledge about the Dutch system concerning work, housing, and the form of the government, in addition to the information that focuses on Dutch culture, traditions and practices. To secure their right to remain in the country, refugees must successfully complete these courses, leading to a state of ‘conditional inclusion’ (Etzel 2022, 11). In this sense, the Dutch approach to conditional inclusion, aiming at producing ‘good refugees’, is particularly problematic as it falsely assumes that completing the mandatory integration programme will naturally grant refugees access to the labour market and enable their meaningful participation in the local culture. In the Netherlands, the state’s regulation of settlement spaces for refugees frequently results in their concentration within disadvantaged neighbourhoods and communities. This, in turn, shapes the conditions of their daily lives and integration prospects (Huizinga and van Liempt 2024). The next sections of this article focus on presenting the methodology employed and the findings, where refugees’ digital practices of aspirational place-making are theorised and analyzed in relation to the Dutch asylum and integration approaches to refugees.

Methodology

The outcomes presented in this article derived from the Translocal Lives Research Project, a multi-stakeholder study that aims to identify the various ways in which refugee migrants creatively and/or effectively use technologies, and how this affects the social participation of refugee migrant groups within their host society.¹ Within this larger project, 15 in-depth interviews were conducted with refugees living in the Netherlands. Moreover, collaborative activities have been developed with and by the

participants, including a six-week hands-on programme for experimenting with digital technology and storytelling, and an expert meeting with representatives of non-governmental organisations to discuss the insights of the research process.

As the results in this article are mainly derived from the interviews with newcomers, we provide more information about the participants and the nature of the interviews hereafter. Interviews were conducted between May and July 2021. Participants were refugees with diverse socio-economic and educational backgrounds, who have been living in the Netherlands between 1 and 7 years. There was an important diversity regarding their countries of origin, which include Syria ($N = 6$), Iran ($N = 4$), Turkey ($N = 2$), Pakistan ($N = 2$), and Eritrea ($N = 1$) thus resulting in diverse cultural backgrounds as well. Among the participants, 9 were women and 7 were men between 24 and 47 years old. Snowball sampling was the main method used for contacting the participants for this project. Additionally, we relied on the social networks of one of the authors of this paper, Jaber Mawazini, who arrived in the Netherlands as a refugee in 2015 and has since been actively engaged with numerous formal and informal organisations addressing refugee related issues, particularly regarding the Syrian community. All interviews lasted between 1 h and 30 min and were mainly conducted in English, in line with the participants' preferred language. However, in 4 cases, participants from Syria, Turkey, and Iran opted to use Dutch or Arabic to better express their ideas.

The interviews took place in the context of Covid-19 in which we still experienced partial restrictions in terms of face-to-face encounters. For this reason, and also taking into account the ease of transportation of the participants, 14 of the 15 interviews were conducted online through a video-call. Only one interview was conducted face-to-face in a coffee place in the city of Rotterdam. All interviews were recorded with the permission of the interviewees who gave informed consent prior to participating in this project. Data privacy and confidentiality considerations were discussed with the participants as well. To store the data securely, this process was supported by a data steward who provided best practices for data storage and sharing. This assistance was critical given that some interviewees expressed concerns with the identification of their personal information and life stories. The procedures of this research were approved by the Ethics Board Committee of the Erasmus School of History, Culture and Community at Erasmus University Rotterdam.

Simultaneously, as privileged migrant women researchers in the Netherlands, and as co-authors authors of this paper, Amanda Alencar and Camila Sarria Sanz were highly cognizant of the power dynamics inherent in their positions while interviewing individuals who experienced forced displacement and were navigating their belonging and legal circumstances within Dutch society in markedly distinct ways. This deepened the researchers' commitment to conducting reflexive and situated research with the participants. Collaborating with Jaber, who shared a similar background and experiences with many participants, played a crucial role in enabling this process. His involvement as language and cultural translator greatly contributed to the preparation of the interview guide, while also facilitating communication with the participants.

As the purpose of this article is to understand digital practices of aspirational place-making, conversations touched on participants' personal stories, everyday lives, issues of identities, sense of belonging, individual and collective aspirations, perceptions of the city, and communication practices including digital engagement, data privacy, and

social media use. The interviews also included a media map to discuss participants' media preferences and consumption, sharing practices, content production, privacy issues, and data management, among others. This served as a tool to stimulate a conversation in which the interviewees themselves were able to identify valuable insights about their own media practices and sense of belonging in the host society.

The interviews were transcribed and subsequently entered in NVivo, a qualitative data coding software. Thematic analysis was used to code all material. While we drew upon insights from all the interviews, the stories of six participants are highlighted as illustrative examples of the key themes identified through the analysis. In this study, aspirational place-making is outlined in relation to participants' uses of digital technology for learning, participating in Dutch social life, and offering and extending care and support. In the following sub-sections, we delve into each of those separately.

Digital learning

Refugees in the Netherlands are often confronted with social boundaries through an integration programme that restricts their aspirations to achieve a university degree (Van Heelsum 2017). Throughout the integration trajectory, refugees are provided with a case worker from their local municipality to develop personalised plans and define their individual career goals. However, this approach prioritises the state's objective of ensuring that refugees attain self-sufficiency within a short period of time, which may limit the autonomy and flexibility of their self-making process. The use of digital technology for learning became a way through which participants avoid direct contact with government integration processes that hinder their dreams and add more hardships and challenges. In this section, our attention is directed towards two examples from the interviews in which participants engage with social media to navigate their educational pursuits as an aspirational form of placemaking.

We first turn to the case of Jamila, whose story was previously introduced. Jamila had decided to advance her studies but encountered difficulties when searching for information about the higher education system in the Netherlands. Although Jamila satisfied all the prerequisites for university admission, she faced discouragement when she mentioned her educational aspirations to her case worker, who ignored her intentions and instead told her to seek employment.

So, you say 'I want to go to school and I have this and this' and I completed all their requirements, that was the difficult part. So 'you should do this, you should have this' and when they evaluated my diploma from back home they compared it with a six-month higher education program in the Netherlands, so it was good enough, but when I show to my case worker she said 'ok, that's good, ok, ok,' and when I left she sent me a letter for a job, where to look for a job and where to go to a meeting with different companies. And I said 'what does this mean, I told you I want to go school and you keep sending me to find a job'.

Due to the lingering uncertainty surrounding her ability to finance her studies, Jamila's enrolment in university was delayed. Jamila revealed that after a year of waiting, she unexpectedly received support from a foundation aimed at funding education for refugees and was admitted to a Dutch programme in Sociology, only to be forced to discontinue her studies due to her limited language proficiency. Highlighting the inherent

ambiguity of Dutch integration programmes, Jamila found herself grappling with the inability to effectively plan, having to adapt to preexisting options that failed to consider her unique needs and priorities. In her own words, *'as a newcomer with a language barrier I should have prepared for two or three months minimum'*.

Recognising that waiting for official channels to become available would be time-consuming and arduous, Jamila sought alternative strategies for personal growth. Jamila mentioned that she had subscribed to a wide variety of podcasts that became a valuable resource for working on her communication skills in Dutch which she believed would facilitate job prospects, even if she is unable to secure a place in an English university programme. While engaging with podcasts to learn the Dutch language, Jamila started following social media influencers who inspired her to develop into an activist.

I have a lot of subscriptions but mainly I use it for improving my Dutch, [...], but Oprah, Brene Brown, psychologists, activists, that's my thing now, maybe I'm trying to become an activist so I am gathering information, anything with important information, important things to say I listen.

Social media influencers, both at the microcelebrity level and on a larger scale celebrity, can be described as individuals who have amassed a substantial following on one or multiple social media platforms (Abidin 2017). Social media influencers have played a key role in the professionalisation of user-based practices (Abidin 2017), encompassing goals that extend beyond mere monetisation dynamics. In particular, the life trajectory of a Somali woman activist, who sought refuge in Canada due to the civil war and devoted herself to educational work with children in Somalia, served as a source of inspiration for Jamila's engagement with social media activism.

There is this activist, Somali activist, she is my favorite person I follow her daily activities because she inspires me and I found her out when I started using Instagram and I kept it like that, but now you see I have a lot of people to follow and on Instagram that's why I spend a lot of time, because a lot of people inspire me and I watch everything they post, I read the caption, everything, even comments.

Despite Jamila's keen interest in exploring activists and their content on Instagram, she has encountered obstacles that may impede her own pursuit of online activism. Jamila shared that she struggles with verbal communication and articulating her thoughts, leading to a hindrance in her ability to create content that involves her acting. As she put it, *'Not me because I am not that good in speaking or trying to communicate, putting my mind in words'*. However, in an attempt to prevent any delay in pursuing her aspirations, Jamila said that she wants to motivate friends to be the voice that advocates for social justice issues, while she participates in content production:

I have a friend, she just had a baby but she was really good at acting and making jokes, she is good and I try to convince her to be like an advocate for women here in the diaspora who are going through what she is going through right now as a single mom. I can help her produce it.

Apart from personal challenges, Jamila has raised concerns regarding Instagram's content guidelines after receiving a notification from the platform for sharing information about the situation in Sudan. *'When they sent me a notification, I didn't feel like I broke rules, why are they trying to watch me, what I do or what I share'*. Jamila's story resonates with insights from earlier research showing that social media content

by minority creators is frequently subject to censorship and moderation issues, which, through the use of biased algorithms by digital platforms, help to maintain invisibility of marginalised voices and enhance data surveillance practices (Jaramillo-Dent, Alencar, and Asadchy 2022).

We now turn to the case of Darya, a 35-year-old woman from Iran who experienced obstacles to pursue long-term education and career plans in the Netherlands. Darya was a student of graphic design when she lived in Iran. Darya said she started making plans to resume her studies and become a professional graphic designer. She told us that her bachelor's degree in graphic design was evaluated to cover two out of the three years of the programme in Dutch education. Yet, the challenge of learning Dutch has become the most significant hurdle in pursuing her dream. Darya shared that since she arrived in the Netherlands in 2015 she could not be admitted to a formal design programme because of limitations in the Dutch language. In light of these constraints, social media proved to be the right avenue for Darya to attain her learning goals. As Witteborn (2019) showed, access to resources through digital technology has significantly amplified aspirational mobility for newcomers by facilitating skills acquisition and, consequently, enabling them to present themselves more effectively. In the case of Darya, she said she uses social media platforms to maintain constant communication with people inside and outside the Netherlands, while she actively endeavours to enhance her skills and improve herself as a graphic designer by following the accounts of graphic designers and people who share similar interests on Instagram: *'I learn a lot of things from those people and pages'*.

However, relying on social media platforms for learning not only demands a substantial amount of Darya's energy and attention, but also requires building her online identity. During the interview, Darya shared that she only began using social media after her arrival in the Netherlands, as they were prohibited in Iran due to government control of the internet. While learning about these apps and platforms, Darya mentioned that she had not yet become very active in sharing content online. This was related to concerns regarding the lack of trust in social media, which played a significant role in shaping the kind of presence she aspires to establish on these platforms:

I do not agree with the people who share their daily lives on social media. I do not trust these applications actually. But I prefer to share something that is related to my work as a graphic designer. I am trying to be as professional as possible on social media.

Consequently, the time invested in learning about graphic design skills from digital content creators inspired Darya to become a type of social media user who leverages these platforms for starting an online business to sell her services, reaching a broader audience, and liberating herself from the constraints of government integration policies. Despite the arduous journey of informal learning through social media, Darya believes that this is the most effective means of achieving integration and transforming her dreams into tangible reality: *'In the future, I want to create a page for me to share my graphic designs and my artworks. This is my purpose'*.

Digital social participation

Social relationships play a crucial role in refugees' prospects of a new life in their host country (Alencar and Tsagkroni 2019; Borselli and van Meijl 2021). Borselli and van

Meijl (2021) showed that refugees' aspiration to integrate was related to the idea of 'embedding with the people', in particular with the host population. Participants in our study emphasised their desire to participate in the social life of their community by fostering connections with Dutch people. However, they reported experiencing different obstacles to socialisation. The cases of two participants, Elif and Samir, illustrate these challenges and the role played by digital technologies in the relational aspect of their aspirational place-making. Elif, a 42-year-old woman from Turkey, had been living in the Netherlands for two years, of which fifteen months were spent at the asylum seekers centre (AZC). Elif talked about the stark contrast between her tranquil and inactive life at the centre and her previously busy work routine in the major Turkish cities of Istanbul, Ankara, and Izmir. Despite the limited activities available at the centre, Elif mentioned that newcomers can still socialise with a lot of Dutch people, but they have to schedule appointments to see them. This was a practice that aligned more with her personal preferences, and it was very different from the dynamic of spontaneous visits from friends in Turkey who would show up at her house without an appointment.

At that time, Elif said that she began to actively use websites and social media platforms that offer instruction on Dutch language and provide insights into Dutch culture, but despite her efforts, she encountered difficulties adapting to cultural differences in relationships with Dutch people. As she describes,

Here, I like it, but sometimes Dutch people are very direct and they say what they want to say directly, which was very hard for me. I used to learn and I like it too. I am trying to be direct.

As an example, Elif told us that after visiting one of her Dutch friends' house for the first time, she received a call from this friend saying that she should not have come with her daughter and husband. Elif said that she acknowledged the difficult situation arising from language barriers that prevented her husband and daughter from communicating with her friend, but that if such a situation occurred in Turkey, she would discontinue her contact with that friend. While Elif initially turned to social media for navigating information about cultural challenges, she needed to experience them in practice:

I learned from the internet and social media about Dutch people, but I did not understand what it meant until she called me and told me about my husband and my daughter. Then, I understood the differences between Turkish people and Dutch people.

For Elif, social media platforms served a 'utilitarian purpose' in terms of providing her with information and supporting her aspirations for social participation and belonging, but they were not a substitute for engaging with people directly to understand their perspectives on relationships. *'I know that she did not mean anything bad about us, but this was her way to tell people what she feels, it is her lifestyle. I am trying to learn this'*.

However, refugees' relational aspirations may also shift due to cultural differences in how socialising is perceived and practiced in their host country. Samir's case is an example. Samir, a 20-year-old man from Syria, has been living in the Netherlands for five years. Samir was preparing to go to university while working part-time at a supermarket. He explained that his work routine allowed him to engage in continuous and spontaneous communication with his Dutch colleagues, corroborating findings from previous research which stated that the daily routine of refugees had a significant

impact on their social interactions with local hosts, surpassing the influence of language skills (Borselli and van Meijl 2021). As Samir put it:

I think, ya, language, but not really. I mean, it is surely a challenge for all newcomers in the Netherlands. For me, it was easier to learn Dutch because I was always in contact with people who speak Dutch. Also, working at Albert Heijn [supermarket] made the learning process much easier.

Even though Samir's job allowed for socialisation, it did not help him build close friendships with his Dutch colleagues. Similarly, he did not perceive social media as a tool that could aid him in making new social connections. When asked about the reason for this, Samir referred to differences regarding how time is managed and valued in Syria and the Netherlands. In contrast to Elif, Samir felt that the need to make social plans resulted in fewer chances to engage with the Dutch, especially when compared to people from his own cultural background. These constraints prompted him to negotiate and adapt his aspirations for social embeddedness:

So, I just wanted to be integrated into this culture and be part of their communities. But after some time, I realized that it is not necessary to be with Dutch people per se. I can be with the people who come to the Netherlands as newcomers, like you.

Samir's experience challenges normative understandings of integration that characterise the host society as a homogeneous and static entity (Spencer and Charsley 2021). The reality is that people like Samir must navigate not just Dutch culture, but also the broader multicultural Dutch society, particularly when living in diverse neighbourhoods (Huizinga and van Liempt 2024). This underscores the need for more nuanced approaches to migrants' social relationships and processes of belonging within superdiverse contexts such as the Netherlands.

Digital social support

Scholars have identified social support as a crucial element for enhancing the psychosocial well-being of refugees and navigating integration processes (Alencar 2018). Refugees can utilise social media as a platform to build networks that enable the access to different kinds of social support, including informational and emotional support, community belongingness, the cultivation of shared identities, recognition of one's value and social positions, and freedom from discrimination (Udwan, Leurs, and Alencar 2020). Through the examples of Nahid and Rayan, we show how social support through digital platforms shapes aspirational place-making for refugees as they navigate the challenges of seeking asylum recognition and belonging.

Nahid, a 40-year-old Iranian woman, endured difficult times in the Dutch refugee camps until she was granted her residence permit. She recounted her experience of living in more seven refugee camps for over two years before finally establishing her residence in the Netherlands. Having a deep understanding of the emotions that accompany the wait for asylum seeking procedures, Nahid said she wants to support her fellows who remain in the camp:

When I was in the refugee camp, I was very communicative and helpful. I am still helpful and I like to give a hand to people and support them, which is by nature. I have contact with my friends who are still in the refugee camp.

Nahid describes the situation of people in the camps in terms of those who are waiting for the asylum interview with the Dutch Immigration Office and need advice on how to proceed and those who have completed the interview but are anxiously awaiting the decision. As experienced by Nahid, the lengthy asylum procedures and uncertainty about the future can lead to disappointment, causing psychological problems for those residing in the refugee camp. For Nahid, WhatsApp became a key enabler of the supportive infrastructure that she created and maintained, allowing her to check on her fellows, support them emotionally and give them advice to overcome the challenges and reach their goals. In addition to easing the burden of prolonged waiting for asylum seekers (Twigt 2018), Nahid's support through the app was meant to preserve their 'capacity to aspire' for a better life in their host country (Appadurai 2019). As Nahid said, *'They need help and hope. For that, I give them advice to stay active, to learn Dutch and start thinking about their future to keep themselves busy with other things than waiting and thinking'*.

At the same time, the app served as a significant means to connect to other refugees who were struggling with the integration system in the Netherlands. Nahid mentioned that she joined multiple WhatsApp groups where she actively shared information regarding educational resources for Dutch language classes, humorous content and photos, and also organised church-related events and activities. Being a member of these groups gave Nahid a strong sense of engagement within the different migrant communities, as they shared common interests and personal experiences, and aspirations. This bond was nurtured through the platform, shaping distinct forms of belonging (Jaramillo-Dent, Alencar, and Asadchy 2022). During her interview, Nahid highlights that Dutch migration policies are structured in a way that creates a distinction between Dutch and non-Dutch individuals, which helps maintain the stigmatising label of the 'refugee'. According to Nahid, a 'platform' needs to be created to enable refugees to share their stories with Dutch people in order to foster their recognition as valued members of their host society. Yet, sharing information about one's life online can be challenging for refugees due to government surveillance (Witteborn 2021). Nahid, for instance, said she was reluctant to share personal experiences on social media because she fears that the Iranian government may question her family based on what she posts in addition to the possibility that some people might use this information for malicious purposes.

I try in the Netherlands to share the least information that I have to share to get access to applications. Not only because of the Iranian government, but we should not share our information because some people will be able to use this information in a bad way. There is no problem with sharing official information, but personal information not. Moreover, some people share every detail of their lives on Instagram, what they do, what they eat, where they go, etc.

In this sense, concerns related to the online sharing of personal information among refugees can undermine their use of digital media for social support, recognition and belonging (Georgiou 2019). However, the case of Rayan demonstrates how digital migrant visibility is expressed in nuanced and multifaceted forms to seek aspirational support. Rayan left Pakistan when he was 21 years old due to religious persecution against Christians in his country of origin. Together with his mother and sister, he has been living in

the Netherlands for five years trying to secure asylum protection in the country. Their unstable situation makes them depend on the help of people from the church to sustain themselves and find temporary shelter across different Dutch cities. Rayan's utmost goal is to acquire a status that allows him to study psychology and find a decent job at a hospital. To achieve his goal, he said he refrains from making friendships and engaging romantically, while simultaneously using social media as a means to explore potential opportunities and keep himself motivated:

I don't make many friends because I have to focus on my life and my studies. I get friend requests from girls because they like brown guys, but it's a waste of time. I always look for opportunities when I use Facebook or Instagram and while I'm doing my own things, I still look for opportunities. Even if you are watching Instagram videos, you need to see what people are doing to get some motivation from them.

Likewise, Rayan highlighted that he actively engages in social media to speak to people, motivate them, and offer encouragement during moments of weakness and depression. In so doing, he tries to build his personal brand on social media as an influencer, fashion model, and modernist individual, despite lacking a formal identity or official status that defines his social position and rights in the Netherlands. As an asylum seeker, Rayan lacks the right to work, a condition that forces him to endure exploitative labour conditions, such as extended work hours and meagre payment, in order to earn some money to send to his father who stayed in Pakistan.

If I work in black, people are not going to pay me well, and I have to work for 12 h like a donkey. On Instagram, I got a few offers to do modelling for some companies. They wanted to pay only 6 euros per hour. That is not what I want to do.

At the same time, social media data from asylum seekers are being used by governments in Europe as part of the asylum application process, making migrants' digital visibility a liability (Witteborn 2021). Even though Rayan has an active presence on social media, he does not express concerns or awareness regarding the possible utilisation of his digital data by Dutch institutions. Instead, he draws attention to the risks of hacking and fraud resulting from sharing personal data on social media platforms and the strategies he adopts to protect himself.

Ofentimes, I receive verifications on my phone. I do not create a password on any website until I login with one of my accounts on Facebook, Instagram and Snapchat. If I login with my email, I will receive a message on my mobile phone number, not on my email. Then, I login with that.

As reported by Rayan, his friends shared bad experiences in these online platforms which made him aware of the risks of online data exposure. Consequently, Rayan's strategies demonstrate the significance of refugees' social (mediated) connections in enhancing data literacy, potentially aiding migrants in safeguarding their digital data and enabling the creation and fulfilment of aspirational places both within and beyond the digital realm.

Conclusions and discussion

The goal of this study was to analyze the agency of refugees as they navigate possible futures amidst integration approaches that emphasise the host government's normative

ideas about preferred outcomes, rather than focusing on the process itself (Spencer and Charsley 2021). To do so, the concept of *aspirational place-making* was proposed and used as a lens to provide new understanding of the myriad strategies that refugees employ to (re)construct plans for their lives and fulfil their aspirations as newcomers in the Netherlands. This study adopted a refugee-centered approach and focused on different everyday digital practices that newcomers have adopted to navigate the host society's approach to integration. It moves beyond the traditional binaries concerning the role of technology in migration, as discussed in this special issue (Godin, Ozcul, and Humphris 2025). The empirical findings yielded three digital practices that describe the participants' quest for reclaiming control over their futures, time, and dreams: (1) digital learning, (2) digital social participation, and (3) digital social support. It is precisely such a quest what makes these digital practices the means for *aspirational place-making*; they are inherently subjective and respond to the unique trajectories of each participant.

In line with the above, the use of *aspirational place-making* enables a deeper understanding of digital practices beyond a purely utilitarian approach (Awad and Tossell 2021). In general, research that investigates the intersection between (forced) migration and technologies does so to highlight the utilitarian goal of the latter: learning a new language, searching for a job, sending money to family members, getting around the city, among others. However, as we have seen throughout the stories of the participants in this study, digital practices are also related to how they negotiate their sense of belonging and aspirations. For instance, the use of digital media by Jamila and Darya to learn the Dutch language and acquire graphic design skills, respectively, can be seen as strategic steps towards realising their educational goals. In the case of Elif, the 'utility' of social media is exemplified through her engagement in seeking information that can help fulfil her aspiration to socialise with Dutch people. This aspirational dimension is often neglected in migrant integration research as well as in the field of media and migration (Borselli and van Meijl 2021; Witteborn 2019), despite it being crucial in foregrounding the agency of refugees to (re)build place and belonging.

Although this study has an exploratory focus, it nevertheless offers valuable insights into the myriad ways in which migrants perceive and experience the (lack of) opportunities presented by everyday digital practices. Moreover, by prioritising individual and in-depth accounts, we were able to shed light on the subjectivities that influence the effectiveness of digital tools in the integration process of newcomers in the Netherlands, while simultaneously encompassing the diversity of experiences among refugees in this study. What is underscored by the narratives shared in this article is the need for developing a more systematic understanding of the multifaceted ways in which digital practices intersect with *aspirational place-making* and the complexities of navigating a new socio-cultural landscape, as well as a broader perspective that can inform (and transform) the current integration approach of countries like the Netherlands; a dominant approach that, as we have learnt, provides limited space for the individual choices and pathways of those who arrive uninvited. To do so, we recommend further research, in the Dutch but also in other contexts, to expand the application of the notion of *aspirational place-making* while allowing for refining it.

The analysis of *aspirational place-making* undertaken here, has also extended insights into the challenges associated with the use of digital technologies by resettled refugees.

The findings revealed tensions that exist in migrants' ability to enact voice and identity within online spaces (Jaramillo-Dent, Alencar, and Asadchy 2022), particularly in relation to participants' distrust in social media platforms and concerns about government surveillance in their home countries. These factors imposed constraints on the pursuit of aspirational places and goals in the digital realm, including endeavours such as 'becoming a digital activist', 'curating a professional online persona', or 'establishing a digital storytelling platform for both refugees and host communities'. Considering these challenges, this study emphasises the need to further investigate the intersections between *aspirational place-making* and digital data surveillance practices by governments in resettlement countries, which has the potential to limit refugees' rights to protection (Witteborn 2021). As exemplified by Rayan's story, his online self-expressions of identity aspirations prioritise digital visibility, overlooking the possible risks these practices may pose to his asylum procedure in the Netherlands. Further research on these questions would be a useful way of exploring how refugees' aspirations in digital place-making processes shape their literacy and agency to navigate online spaces for belonging and recognition.

Note

1. To explore this, the project utilised a participatory research design that included participants with lived experiences of forced displacement, a media artist, academic researchers, and key informants from the refugee community in the Netherlands.

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